



Raciolinguistics: How Language Shapes Our Ideas About Race

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<https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780190625696.001.0001>

Published: 2016

Online ISBN: 9780190625726

Print ISBN: 9780190625696

CHAPTER

5 “Suddenly Faced with a Chinese Village”: The Linguistic Racialization of Asian Americans

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<https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780190625696.003.0006> Pages 97–112

Published: November 2016

Abstract

This chapter examines how Whites positioned Asian American residents of a community in California as toxic and unwelcome neighbors. It looks at the kinds of moral evaluations that they made as they positioned Asian Americans as nefarious businessmen; as greedy “newcomers” who did not “care” about the community; and as hypercompetitive students who were not well-rounded. Whites associated speaking an Asian language with deception and secrecy and framed displays of Asian languages in public space as inappropriate. While some research has claimed higher-income Asian Americans are assimilating rapidly and that increasing rates of Asian American residential segregation are voluntary choices, this chapter suggests that racialization is still a potent force.

Keywords: Asian American, White, racialization, listening subject, model minority, assimilation, California, multilingualism

Subject: Sociolinguistics

In recent years, glowing portraits of Asian American immigrants have circulated widely in the American press. “Not only are Asian Americans the fastest-growing racial group in the country, but they have the highest incomes, are the best-educated and are happier with their lot in life compared with other groups,” announced the *San Francisco Chronicle* in October 2012 (Garofoli 2012). Building upon a Pew Research Center report noting that the number of immigrants from Asia who arrived in the United States in 2010 surpassed the number of Latino immigrants that year (“The Rise of Asian Americans,” cited in Garofoli 2012), several articles have contrasted these two groups. For example, one *Wall Street Journal* (WSJ) article cast Latinos in the image of an “unstoppable wave of unskilled, mostly Spanish-speaking workers—many illegal.” For the WSJ (and many others; see chapters 3 and 18, this volume), Latinos embodied widespread anxieties that “today’s immigrants” were “less ambitious, less skilled, less willing and able to assimilate.” Asian Americans were instead depicted as the polar opposite of Latinos: “The world’s best, the world’s hardest-working and the world’s most ambitious are still coming our way” (Mead 2012). The Pew report itself celebrated this image of Asian Americans as the “model minority,” celebrating measures of income, intermarriage, and residential patterns as evidence of their assimilation:

A century ago, most Asian-Americans were low-skilled, low-wage laborers crowded into ethnic enclaves and targets of official discrimination. Today they are the most likely of any major racial or ethnic group in America to live in mixed neighborhoods and to marry across racial lines.

(“The Rise of Asian Americans” 2012, 1)

p. 98 As scholars of race have noted, discourses like these, which pit Asian Americans against Latinos and African Americans, divert attention away from the structural forces of White racism that underlie racial inequalities (Abelmann and Lie 1995; Kim 1999; Palumbo-Liu 1999; Prashad 2000). By framing the racialization of Asian Americans as a thing of the distant past and no longer present today, such narratives imagine Asian Americans as “honorary Whites” (Tuan 1998). When contemporary racial discrimination is acknowledged at all in these depictions, it is often cast as something that is on the verge of disappearing.

But does this idyllic portrait of wealthy, happy, high-achieving, educationally successful, fully assimilated Asian Americans actually describe what life is like on the ground? As research in Asian American studies has demonstrated, the fact that Asian Americans have largely achieved parity with Whites in arenas like educational achievement can be read as a *response* to racialization, not as evidence of its absence (Sue and Okazaki 1990; Suzuki 1977). Indeed, relatively little work has explored the lives of those who seem to have all of the stereotypical qualities of the “model minority.” Instead, researchers have attempted to document the broad socioeconomic, ethnic, religious, and cultural diversity of those who are lumped together under the term “Asian American” (Espiritu 2003; Ong 2003; Reyes 2007). In this chapter, I look specifically at the experiences of suburban, upper-middle-class Asian Americans who were living in a community in California that I call Laurelton.

I argue that Asian Americans were strongly racialized by White residents through language, as Whites positioned Asian Americans discursively as racial others, while interpreting their linguistic production through racializing frames. This work builds upon research in linguistic anthropology, which has looked at how racialization can manifest through subtle discursive patterns, not simply in words that are, in and of themselves, considered “racist” (Alim and Smitherman 2012; Bucholtz 2011; Chun 2009; Hill 2008; Reyes 2007). I consider the interworkings of race and language at two levels. First, I examine how Whites located themselves and Asian Americans in moral and social space through talk about “newcomers” and “oldtimers.” At the discursive level, these forms of covert racialization situated Asian Americans as illegitimate, peripheral members of the community and centered Whites as legitimate residents. Asian Americans who fit the model minority stereotype, and who are often imagined as leading fully assimilated lives, are covertly racialized through discourses about language. Through their pronoun use and the ways that they associated categories like “Asian,” “newcomer,” and “oldtimer” with moral positions, Whites portrayed themselves as the rightful, central members of Laurelton.

p. 99 I examine how Whites read the linguistic production of Asian Americans, interpreting their language use as an emblem of their foreignness. This ethnographic approach illustrates the fact that class does not always trump race, as upper-middle-class Asian Americans who lived near Whites did not find themselves especially welcomed by them. I argue that linguistic racialization is central to analyzing the place of Asian Americans in the changing American racial landscape. Popular culture imagines Asian Americans as essentially White. On the ground, however, Whites in Laurelton strenuously distanced themselves from Asian Americans through language.

White Raciolinguistic Imaginaries: How White Americans Imagine Asian Americans and “Their Language”

Images of Asian Americans and their linguistic production have been extensively investigated in scholarly research on race and racism. Robert Park’s (1950) influential work on assimilation, for example, read group processes of assimilation through a family narrative of the Oriental parent and child (Yu 2001). In this downscaling project, the centuries-old dichotomy of Asians as both “dangerous threat” and “inspirational model” in the gaze of the West (Clarke 1997; Said 1978) is mapped onto immigrant parents and second-generation children. In his model, language was the key criterion that Whites could use to tell one kind of Asian American from the other. Since outward signs were unreliable (the “mask of the Oriental”), with clothing and the like being read as only “costumes” or “disguises,” spoken English became the definitive sign that Whites could rely upon to distinguish unassimilated Asian Americans from assimilated ones.

Park’s theory of assimilation is thus centered not just on the figure of the Asian American but specifically upon their *linguistic* signaling as perceived by Whites. These two figures—the immigrant who will never lose her grating accent and the descendant of immigrants whose English supposedly bears no trace of accent—embody both the totalizing power and transcendence of a core linguistic ideology. It is an ideology that associates “standard” English with White speakers and nonstandard varieties of English with racialized speakers (Bonfiglio 2002; Jones 1999; Lippi-Green 1997). This “passage” from accented speaker of a vernacular form of English to speaker of an impeccable standard (Gal 2012) positions the family as a crucible of language learning. It further defines language as a kind of racialized inheritance, illustrating how raciolinguistic imaginaries anchor the theory of assimilation.

The Idyllic Suburb?

p. 100 Laurelton was the kind of place many immigrants hope to live in. It had comfortable tree-lined streets, generous playgrounds and parks, and a thriving public school system. The prototypical Laurelton household was a two-parent, dual-income family with school-aged children. While many Laurelton residents spoke of a sharp change in demographics (pointing to the fact that the percentage of Whites had declined from over 90% to near 50% over the past thirty years), this was only the latest in successive waves of immigration over the past few hundred years. Some moved to the area when it was a flourishing agricultural region; others came in the post-World War II era, when modest California bungalows, condos, and apartments replaced farms. Many arrived when the low-priced starter homes of the fifties and sixties had risen in value and had become highly desirable.

The high housing prices in Laurelton meant that most of its residents were well-paid professionals. Laurelton was adjacent both to more upscale communities and to less upscale ones, and it bordered several communities with greater racial diversity. The majority of its residents were White or Asian American. I lived in a (less upscale) community adjacent to Laurelton from 2001 to 2004 and watched as racial dynamics helped fuel White flight from Laurelton and from its schools. As Asian Americans became increasingly visible in Laurelton’s political, civic, and commercial arenas, the community gained a reputation among some Whites for being “too Asian.” Some local White realtors began to steer White home-buyers away, recommending other nearby communities where they might feel more “comfortable.” The Asian Americans who lived in Laurelton were, demographically speaking, “model minorities.” They were, for the most part, well-educated, professional, dual-income families where parents and children were highly proficient speakers of English. Yet, through language used to describe them, they were frequently positioned by others in ways that located them as essentially different and foreign.

Positioning Self and Other

Both Whites and Asian Americans created racial boundaries by delineating categories of people, locating themselves in relation to categories, and endowing these categories with social and moral meaning. For example, through their use of pronouns and terms for people, many White speakers created landscapes in which “Asians” were different from and opposed to “us.” Both White and Asian American Laurelton residents used the term “Asian” to refer to anyone of Chinese, Japanese, Korean, Vietnamese, Thai, Cambodian, and other types of descent, while “Indian” was used largely by Whites to speak about people who could trace their ancestry to India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, or Nepal. While the Asian American population was diverse, Chinese Americans were the largest subgroup. It was common for Whites to use “Chinese” and “Asian” interchangeably. Most Whites did not distinguish between ethnic Chinese from Taiwan, Hong Kong, or China; those who had come from the Chinese diaspora in Southeast Asia, Indonesia, or the Philippines; or those whose families had been in the United States for several generations—all of these were lumped into one group, “Chinese,” in both print and in conversation.

Although White Laurelton residents spoke readily about “Asians” and “Chinese,” they did not usually use the word “White” to refer to themselves. Nor was this a very common term used by Asian Americans, who usually called people of European descent “American.” Both groups used terms like “African American,” “Mexican,” or “Hispanic” for people not racialized as White.

While the relevant local terms were thus “Asian” versus “American,” I use “Asian American” in this chapter to refer to anyone of Asian descent who was living in the United States, and “White” to refer to those of European descent living in the United States. I do this in part because I am uncomfortable with the ways that local categories position Asian Americans in opposition to and as incommensurate with “American.” I recognize that “White” and “Asian American” are racializing terms that erase ethnic, socioeconomic, and religious difference. I use these terms not in support of this racializing project, but as a way of highlighting the ways that Laurelton residents themselves organized the world.

Claims to Place: “Oldtimers” and “Newcomers”

Fieldnote: I drove past one of Laurelton’s many mini-malls and ducked into a Japanese supermarket to grab a quick snack. Elaborately coiffed young Korean American moms held the hands of their stylish tots; Japanese American kids whined to their grandmothers to buy them sweet packaged pastries, and workers from nearby companies ordered bowls of steaming ramen. Signs in both English and romanized Japanese were found throughout the store. I grabbed a prepackaged tuna fish sandwich on airy white bread and went down the street to the Laurelton Historical Society to learn more about the history of the community. Tom, an elderly White man who had moved to Laurelton with his wife as a young married couple, told me that he was an “oldtimer” and offered to lead me, a “newcomer,” around the current exhibit, which traced the history of Laurelton. Historical pictures featured locally prominent families of European descent, shopkeepers, teachers, and agricultural laborers. As I left the historical society and drove past a Japanese American-owned business which was run by third- and fourth-generation Laurelton residents, I couldn’t help thinking about how the exhibit made it seem as though life in the good old days was purely White.

In interviews and in the local newspaper, local White residents presented themselves as legitimate members of the community and Asian Americans as illegitimate ones. Whites routinely referred to themselves as “oldtimers” or “longtime residents,” stressing their ties to nostalgic visions of Laurelton’s rural past. They spoke longingly of the bountiful harvests and “neighborly” interactions of this supposedly more carefree time. Both those whose ancestors were actually involved in agriculture, as well as later arriving White professionals, evoked these images.

Local White residents used the term “oldtimers” in opposition to the term “newcomers.” Newcomers were not seen as rightful residents of Laurelton, but as usurpers who were “taking over” the community. Their “selfish” pursuit of their own interests was linked to their unhealthy relationship with money and property. Whereas “oldtimers” were imagined as people who cared about the land and about their neighbors, “newcomers” were just out to make a quick buck and cared only about themselves. They claimed more than their fair share of public resources and demanded “special treatment” like foreign language classes that were a waste of public money. The discourse of the “newcomer” framed Asian Americans as having come *from* somewhere else to the United States and pointed to their inescapably foreign origins. It linked Whites to the genteel persona of the farmer who lived in a “more relaxed” nostalgic time and space, while linking Asian Americans to the rabidly hypercompetitive neoliberal student/homeowner.

Asian Americans were associated with the more recent and discomfiting changes of suburbanization, overcrowding, and commercialization (Lye 2005; Mitchell 2004). This racializing discourse, however, erased the substantial connection Asian Americans had to Laurelton’s agricultural past. Although Asian Americans had been agricultural laborers and owners of stores that sold produce from the fields, “newcomer” discourses cast them as the primary agents of the unwelcome social changes that had taken place across California over the past decades.

Local White residents created categories of people through the use of pronouns that established moral boundaries. At a city council meeting, one longtime White resident said, “I welcome them to our community, but it is them coming to our community. I don’t want it to change into their community.” Similarly, a White city council member said of an Asian philanthropist, “What do we know about these people?” By drawing distinctions between “our community” and “their community,” and “we” and “these people,” speakers drew moral boundaries between one set of people who were bonafide members of the community and another set of people who were unknown, suspect interlopers. Dismissive references to “these people” and “them” positioned White speakers as morally superior to Asian Americans. Whites used similar forms of evaluative language to talk about local Asian American politicians. One speaker described an Asian American political candidate with the sentence, “His agenda is more about ‘my people.’” Here, Asian Americans are presented as interested only in advancing the narrow interests of the racially exclusive “my people,” not in the welfare of the wider community of Laurelton.

p. 103 Stereotypes of Asian Americans as unfriendly and exclusive were extended not only to immigrants but to their American born children as well. Public schools were imagined as being filled with “overly competitive” Asian American kids. When one realtor told a White family who was considering purchasing a home in the area, “[your] child might be the only Caucasian in the class,” it reinforced the idea that being surrounded by Asian Americans was not something to which you should subject your children. It didn’t take much for Whites to feel that there were “too many” Asian Americans; White flight from the public schools was already apparent by the time Asian Americans comprised a mere third of the overall population.

Asian Americans were surprised by the extent to which they lived separate but unequal lives from Whites in Laurelton. They told me that they participated in racially divided sports leagues, Boy Scout troops, and PTA organizations. In reaction to a reporter’s question about racial tension in a local high school, one Asian American school administrator said, “There is no racial tension because there is no interaction [across racial boundaries].” Recently arrived teens from South Korea told me that they had a difficult time making “American” (e.g., White) friends and were considering transferring to schools in other parts of the state where they thought things might be better.

Many Asian Americans also seemed to resent the presumption that they did not belong in Laurelton regardless of how long they had lived there. When I was at a reception for a local civic organization, I met a South Asian American whom I had just read about in the organization’s newsletter. I asked her a question alluding to her recent hiring: “Oh, so how long have you been here?” I remember being rather taken aback

by her curt response informing me that she had lived in the area for over thirty years. When I asked how long she had been “here,” I meant to refer to her time at the organization, not her time in California or the United States. The fact that she read my question as being stereotypically about her presumed foreignness revealed resentment about being constantly positioned as someone who was not “from here.”

When I asked a woman, an immigrant from Taiwan, how she felt about Laurelton’s racial climate, she told me that she was not entirely prepared for how “Chinese” Laurelton felt to her. According to her, this was at times a disadvantage: “In some ways, it’s just like Taiwan here. All the kids are always studying. ... Sometimes I think we should move to someplace really American, like Seattle. Then the kids could just play outside after school instead” (translated from Mandarin). In fact, when I asked Asian Americans why they had decided to move to Laurelton, they gave many of the same reasons Whites did: stable real estate values, proximity to work, its reputation as a “nice” community. Very few specifically mentioned a desire to be near other Asian Americans as a key reason. The racial segregation that Asian Americans experienced in Laurelton did not happen because Asian Americans voluntarily chose to associate only with other Asian Americans; instead, they were held at arm’s length by White residents who did not welcome their presence.

p. 104

Reading the Linguistic Landscape

Fieldnote: Laurelton’s town green was a large public space frequently used for festivals of various kinds. Such events featured vendors, music, kids’ activities, performances by school groups, and booths by local civic organizations. On festival days, grandmothers would chase after their grandkids, children would dart around scarfing down whatever sweet treat was on sale, and the cries of vendors hawking sunglasses, mobile phone accessories, hats, and kids’ trinkets filled the air. Many of these were generically themed events (e.g., the “food and wine festival”) but occasionally, a festival that was ethnically or racially specific would come along as well (e.g., Oktoberfest, Lunar New Year, Diwali). While Oktoberfest never raised much concern, several of the Asian-associated festivals prompted angry letters to the local newspaper about their “exclusionary” nature. In some cases, vendors in the “international” section were required to sign a pledge that they would not represent any other country in a negative way. In other cases, festivals that had been dedicated to particular Asian groups or holidays were instead converted to “international” festivals. By surrounding attractions such as children doing aikido and Korean drumming troupes, with attractions like firefighters, men in kilts, and high school bands, such festivals were deracialized and made unthreatening. They were transformed into events that were, in the words of those who insisted on these reforms, “welcoming to all.”

Some Whites in Laurelton objected strongly to displays of Asian languages in Laurelton public space. The public presence of Asian Americans, apparent in the stores and restaurants that lined Laurelton’s commercial thoroughfares, was a sharp point of tension. Adjacent communities that had comparable percentages of Asian Americans did not suffer the same kind of friction as there was in Laurelton, partly because of the ways that some residents read public space. In this section, I focus on how some residents interpreted both spoken and visual displays of Asian languages as “foreign” and linked to deception. I understand these not as features of the codes themselves, but as cultural frameworks of interpretation that positioned some kinds of writing and speech as illegible or incomprehensible.

Many White residents were concerned about the ways that Laurelton’s commercial spaces had become “Asian.” Laurelton did not have a quaint downtown, a pedestrian area lined with upscale children’s boutiques, wine bars, and cafes, like some communities in the area. Instead, it had mini-malls, where several small businesses, visible from the street, were clustered around a parking lot in front (see Figure 5.1). The main commercial thoroughfares were packed tightly with restaurants, insurance companies, markets, banks, gas stations, hardware stores, car dealerships, and fast food establishments. It was not

p. 105

uncommon to hear languages other than English being spoken in these places, as well in the public library or the post office. I often spoke Mandarin, Cantonese, or Korean in Laurelton stores and restaurants.

Figure 5.1



A California mini-mall.

Many Whites objected to the ways that commercial spaces in Laurelton catered to Asian American customers, with visual displays of Asian languages seen as especially inappropriate. Some who explicitly mentioned their long residence in the community wrote letters to the editor of the local paper complaining about the “appalling” number of store signs and delivery trucks with writing in a “foreign language.” A study was then commissioned by the town council, which in fact only found a handful of instances in which a sign did not also include an English translation. In these letters, visual displays of Chinese characters were most highly salient in the imagination as “foreign”; signs that used roman letters but whose meaning might have been opaque to English monolinguals nonetheless (e.g., *nước mắm*, *cup ramen shoyu menraku hikari*) were not singled out. Chinese characters could be found on outdoor signs for insurance companies, banks, restaurants, and stores; in posters in store windows; and on printed menus, handwritten strips of paper taped to walls of restaurants, signs inside stores, and labels for food items (see Figure 5.2). ↵

Figure 5.2



Chinese in public space.

p. 107 One market in town was singled out by some Whites as a particularly uninviting space because of its visual displays of language:

ms. harper: Just going down to the [Asian supermarket] And um- you look at that. What do you see? I don't- I don't understand any of the language in that.

ms. wilkins: I'd really like to go there [a local Asian supermarket] But I have no clue what they have.

And so if it's also in English

Maybe more people would go.

In these descriptions, the market is represented as a place where there is no English writing. The experience of being in the market is described as one of utter lack of comprehension for someone who is not literate in Chinese (“I have no clue what they have” “I don’t understand any of the language in that”). In fact, when I went to take a look, I found mostly multilingual signs that featured English alongside writing in Chinese characters. There were some signs that were in Chinese only, such as advertisements for Chinese newspapers or concerts. Yet most of the labels for products were in both English and Chinese, with occasional uses of Vietnamese (which is written with roman letters) and Korean (which uses its own alphabet) (see Figure 5.3).

Figure 5.3



Signs at the Chinese market.

Yet many White residents nevertheless imagined the market as a place with no English. In such descriptions, the mere presence of non-Roman writing alongside English made certain spaces illegible.

Asian Americans were linked not only to undecipherable writing but also to undecipherable speech. As one resident said, “On my block 90 percent [of my neighbors] are Asian. I can’t talk to them.” Here, being “Asian” itself makes someone unable to interact with non-Asians. Such perceptions ignored the fact that most Asian Americans in Laurelton were highly proficient multilinguals who used English on a daily basis at work or at school. By creating a space in which there are “Asians” who are framed in general as linguistically incomprehensible, and by locating himself in opposition to that category, the speaker here covertly replicates stereotypes of Chinese as bad speakers of English and non-Asians as good speakers of English.

Lastly, speaking in a language other than English was also sometimes publicly linked to attempts at deception and secrecy, echoing “yellow peril” discourses that have been used to describe crafty Chinese and

devious Japanese among others (Lye 2005). In one letter to the editor, a resident expressed her feelings about the development of a local mini-mall:

p. 108

There has been quite a bit of publicity lately in [the local paper] regarding the future of the city center. City officials and [the] director ↵ of community development were quoted as being delighted with the new ownership.

When I met with [the director of community development] and questioned him regarding the new owners' plans regarding the city center, he stated that the city had no jurisdiction regarding the usage of the acquired property.

That explains how Laurelton was suddenly faced with a "Chinese Village" at the corner of [...] roads, which was originally billed as a supermarket but blossomed into the present enclave after negotiations were carried out in Chinese and with a "hands-off" attitude by the city.

The new owners, Mr. Wong and his Asian partners, have denied that their international restaurant would cater exclusively to Asian clients, but his credibility would be increased if some European flavor would be included in his planning and the veil of secrecy so dear to his business planning [...] would be lifted.

In this letter, the languages that people speak make them more or less trustworthy.

p. 109

"Mr. Wong and his Asian partners" are depicted as conducting business negotiations in Chinese, thereby creating a "veil of secrecy" around their plans to develop a local mall. Just as Spanish speakers are sometimes prohibited from speaking Spanish on the job because they are thought to be trying to hide something from English monolinguals, carrying on "negotiations in Chinese" is here associated with attempts to deceive the good citizens of Laurelton (who are thus implicitly positioned as not Chinese). Specifically, the words of "Mr. Wong and his Asian partners" are not to be trusted; they might claim that they are not building a restaurant that will serve only Chinese, but we should not really believe them because there are no Whites (e.g., "European flavor") involved in this project. Here, speaking Chinese is associated with plotting nefarious deeds and making false public promises. Similarly, spaces associated with Chinese are deemed inherently exclusionary to others.

This letter is written in the hyperbolic style that was common in letters to the editor in this newspaper. The local newspaper was a place where passionate opinions were expressed; people that I interviewed in person did not make statements that were nearly as forceful. Nevertheless, such texts covertly racialized Asian Americans in Laurelton by evoking stereotypes of the Chinese language as less "straightforward" than Western languages, and as linked to "convoluted" modes of writing and expression. They also upheld English as the language of honesty, transparency, and candor.

Conclusion

In this chapter, I have shown how Asian Americans who fit the model minority stereotype, and who are often imagined as leading fully assimilated lives, are covertly racialized through discourses about language. In local discourses that recalled the “yellow peril,” Whites portrayed well-educated, multilingual Asian Americans as nefarious businessmen; as greedy “newcomers” who did not “care” about the community; and as hypercompetitive students who were not well-rounded. Attempts by Asian Americans to revitalize commercial areas, to get involved in local politics, or to remodel their homes were seen as threatening and exclusionary, unseemly displays of wealth that contrasted with oldtimer Whites’ genteel relationships to the land. Through their pronoun use and the ways that they associated categories like “Asian,” “newcomer,” and “oldtimer” with moral positions, Whites portrayed themselves as the rightful, central members of Laurelton.

p. 110

At the same time, discourses that associated speaking an Asian language with deception and secrecy, and that depicted written displays of Asian languages in public spaces as illegible and inappropriate, circulated in letters to the editor of the local paper. In such letters, writers voiced strong opposition toward public celebrations of Asian-identified holidays on the town green or towards “special ↵ services” like classes at the library in languages other than English. Just as World War II helped to speed language loss among German-speaking and Japanese-speaking American communities, associations in Laurelton between speaking in an Asian language and dishonesty promoted English monolingualism.

While statistics may lead us to believe that Asian Americans are being readily accepted by Whites, a closer look shows that merely living among Whites is not the same as being accepted by them. This should not be surprising. Many communities the world over are characterized by both close proximity *and* sharp divisions along ethnic, religious, or racial lines. Indeed, the residential concentration of highly educated, high-income Asian Americans in U.S. metropolitan areas actually increased from 1990 to 2000 (Iceland and Wilkes 2006). These patterns may not be due to Asian Americans voluntarily “choosing” to live among other Asian Americans. It may very well be that racializing discourses like the ones described above, where Whites linguistically portrayed Asian Americans as toxic and unwelcome neighbors, help to spur White flight from communities that have become “too Asian” (Zhou, Tseng, and Kim 2009).

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